means in a multi-religious country. In the process I devote as much space to the ideological contestations and political challenges swirling around the faith today as I do to its timeless metaphysics.

The book is divided into three sections. The first section, 'My Hinduism', looks at every aspect of the religion—its principal schools, tenets, teachers, and teachings, as well as some of its more questionable social practices. The second section, 'Political Hinduism', explains the ways in which political leaders, strategists, thinkers and their religious allies have attempted to hijack the faith for their own ends. The third section, 'Taking Back Hinduism', talks about how we might free Hinduism from the excesses and perversions it has been subjected to, and restore it to its truest essence, which in many ways is that of an almost ideal faith for the twenty-first-century world.

To some readers, my title—'Why I am a Hindu'—begs the question of who really is this 'I' that I refer to. Is it the thoughtful Hindu layman, the product of a modern English-language education in contemporary India, who is interrogating himself about the faith to which he claims adherence? Or is it the politician steeped in the issues of the day, who is writing with a sense of urgency and despair conditioned by the experience of being called 'anti-Hindu' by those who understand far less of the faith but are inflamed by their own ideological certitudes? My claims about being Hindu are undoubtedly mediated by political contestations around the public expressions of Hinduism by those who see it as a badge of identity more than a system of transcendental beliefs. But where I disagree with them, I do so not as a secularist—or as they would allege, a 'pseudo-secularist'—standing outside the faith, but as a believing Hindu who seeks to challenge them from within the bounds of the religion to which we both claim allegiance.

In some ways I am guilty of the old Indian failing of trying to depict the elephant by describing its tail, tusk, girth and so on. As a result I can at best approximate a number of truths in my effort to describe the unknowable whole truth. Hinduism is uniquely difficult to encapsulate for reasons I describe in my opening chapter: no single founder or prophet, no organised church, no single holy book, and so on; the faith is almost Wikipedia-like in the authorial diversity of its scriptures and